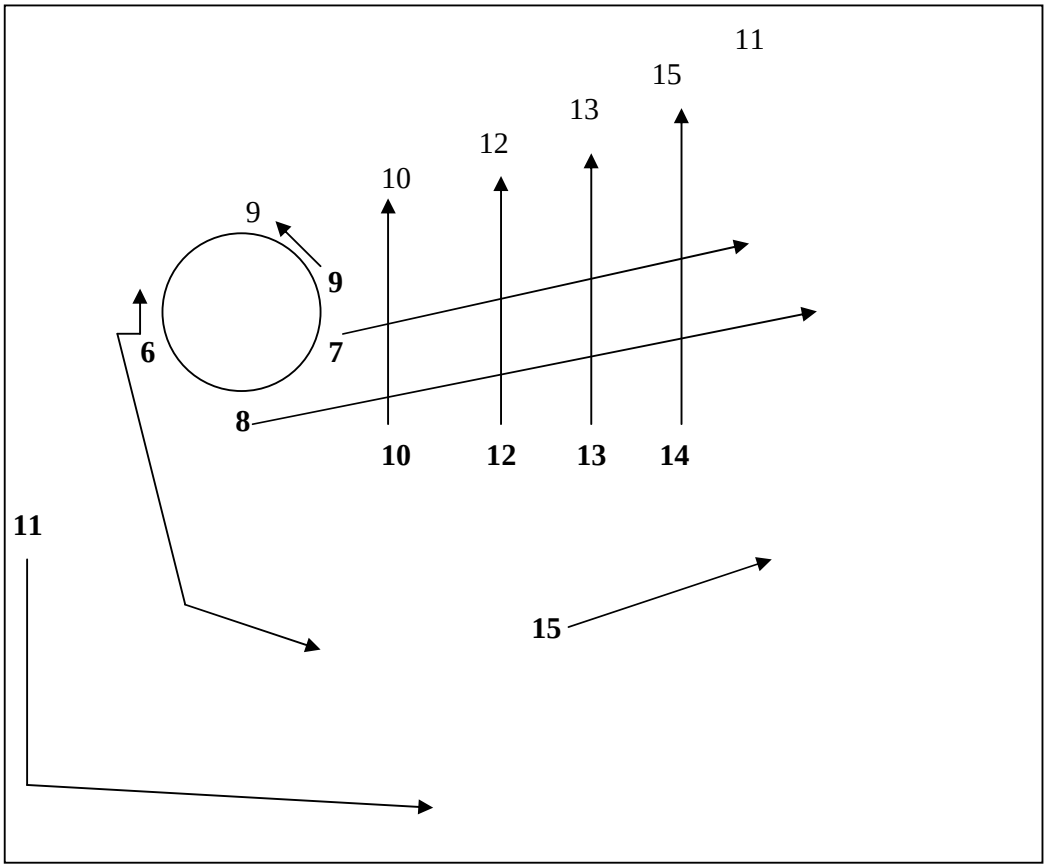
DEFENSIVE PATTERNS:

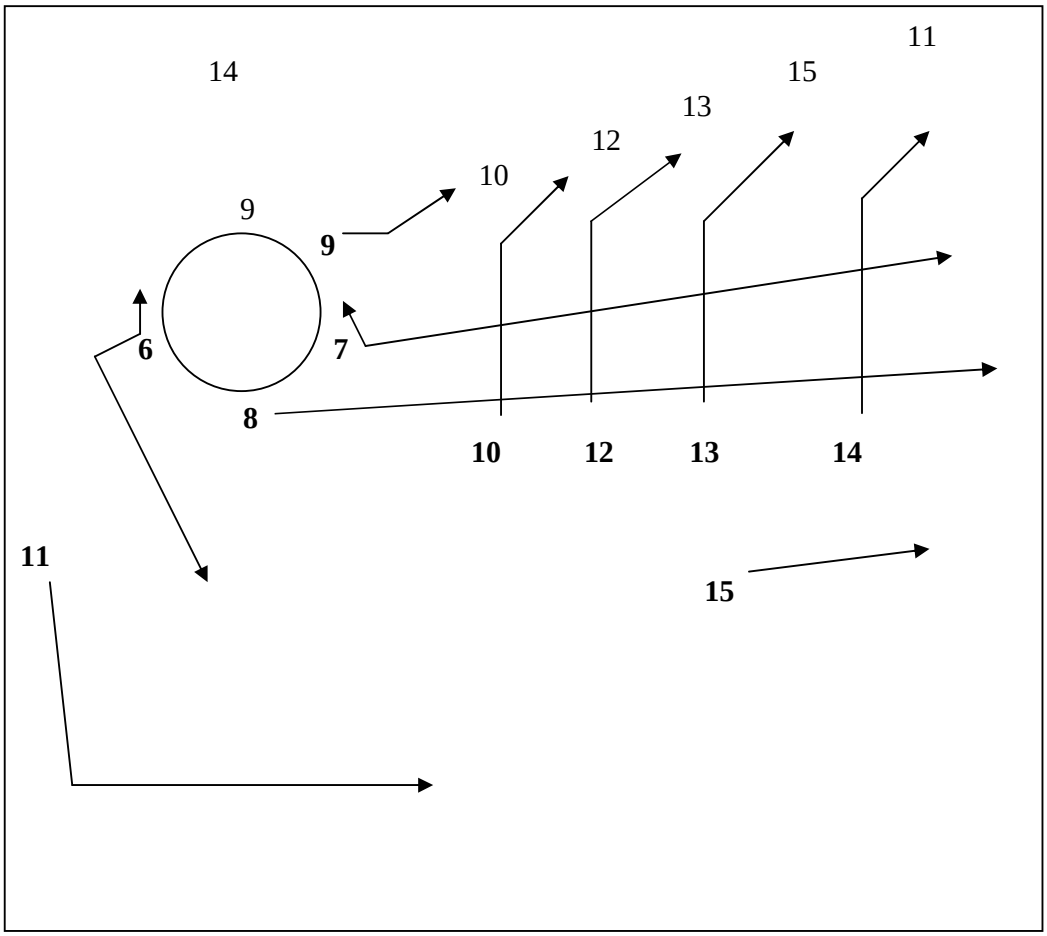
Defence from a Left Scrum:

A. *Man on Man*:



9 goes for his opposite number first and then moves behind his backline covering any missed tackles.
7 first covers the inside of 10 and then moves across the field behind his backs. He must always stay in the inside of the ball, so he can cover the inside gaps.
8 moves straight across the field behind the backs, watching for any missed tackles.
6 must first check if they are going blind. He must support 11 if they kick or cross cover.
11 falls back deep for the box kick and then moves across the field after their flyhalf has passed.
Backline must tackle man on man from the inside. They must come up together.
Tight Forwards 3, **2** and **5** take the shortest route and **1** and **4** take a slightly deeper route to the ball.

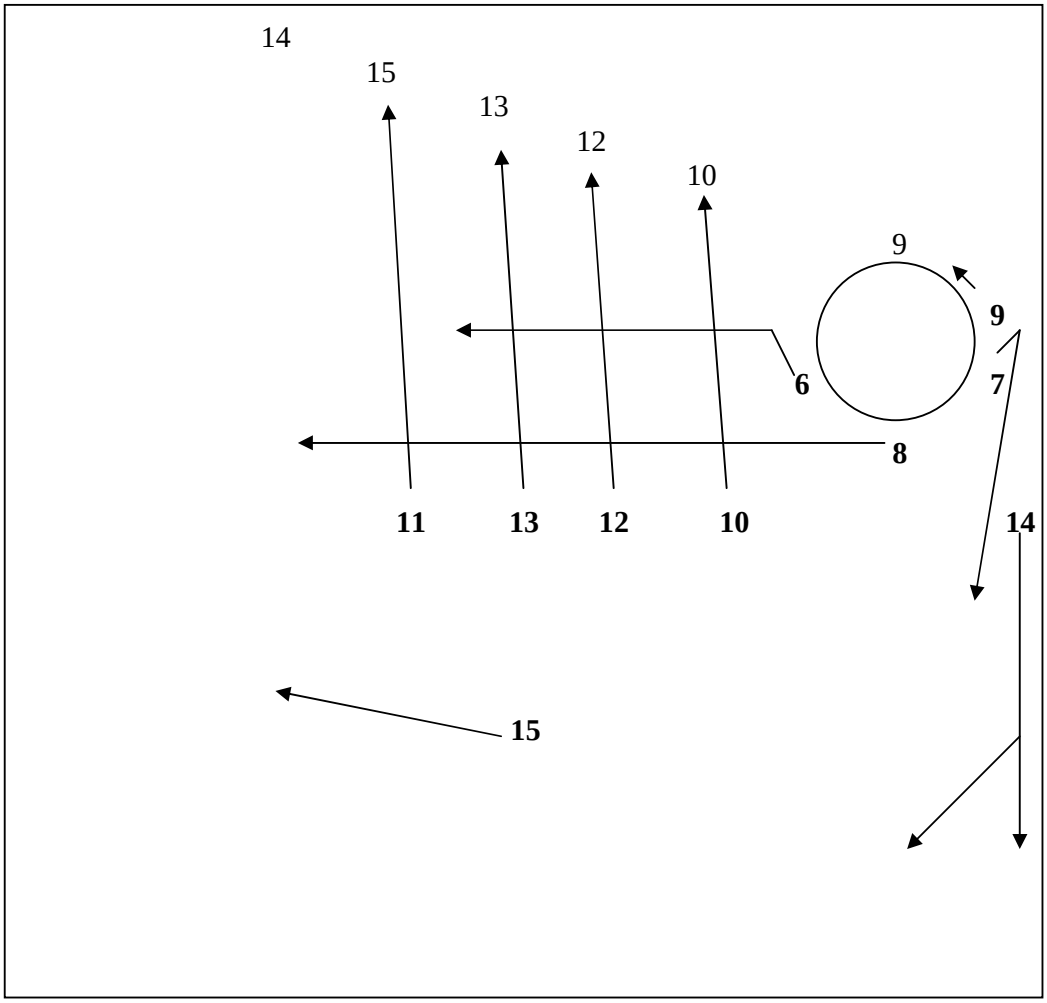
B. *Drift Defence*:



9 moves away from the scrum and takes their 10 and then puts the rest of their backline under pressure (he is only allowed to move 1m away, but play the ref).
Backline shifts one down and comes up together. They must stay in their channels.
7 watches their 9 and then moves across the field closing all inside gaps behind his backline.
8 also moves across the field watching for inside gaps and staying on the inside of the ball.
6 watches the blind and then falls back deep. If there is no kick he cross covers.
11 still watches for the box kick and then moves across the field watching for missed tackles or kicks.
15 always covers 2/3 of the field and the other 1/3 is covered by the wing.
Tight Forwards the same.

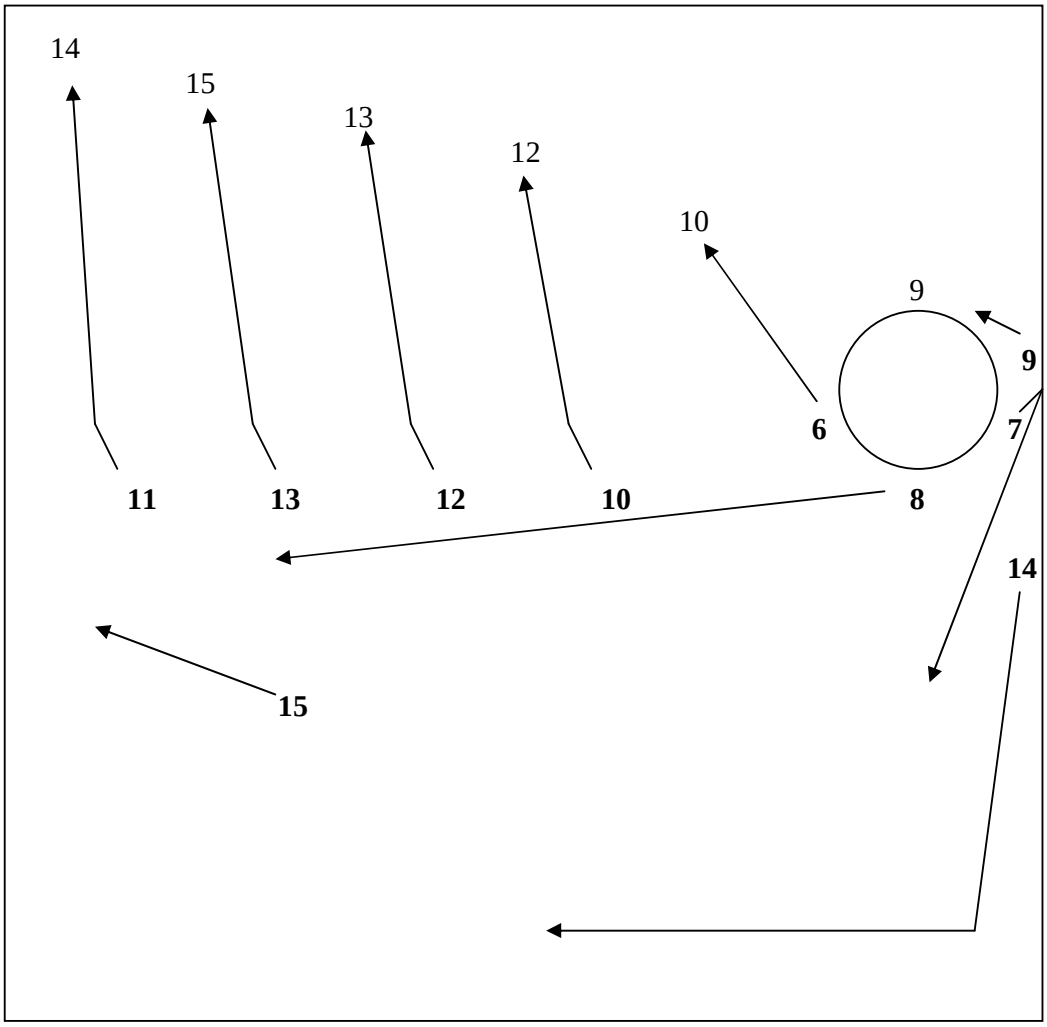
Defence from a Right Scrum:

A. *Man on Man*:



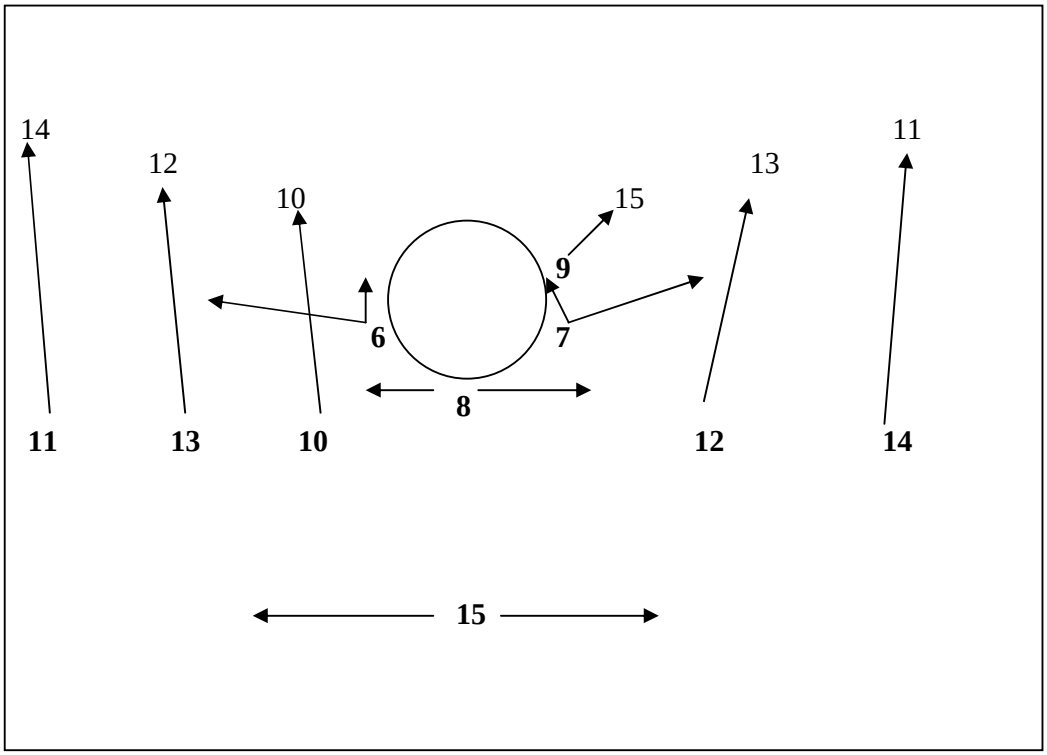
9 applies pressure on his opposite number and also on their 10 if he is standing deep or he moves around the back of his scrum and cover defends.
6 watches for a break around the scrum and then stays on the inside of his 10, until their 10 has passed. He then stays on the inside of the ball covering behind his backline.
Backline takes man on man from the inside and stay in their channels.
8 comes across the field (not over running the ball) watching for any breaks or kicks.
14 falls back deep watching for a box kick. After their 10 has passed he moves across the field.
7 makes sure that they are not going blind and then falls back deep. If there is no kick he cross covers.
Tight Forwards on the left **1**, **2** and **4** take the shortest root and the right **3** and **5** take deeper root.

B. *Drift Defence*:



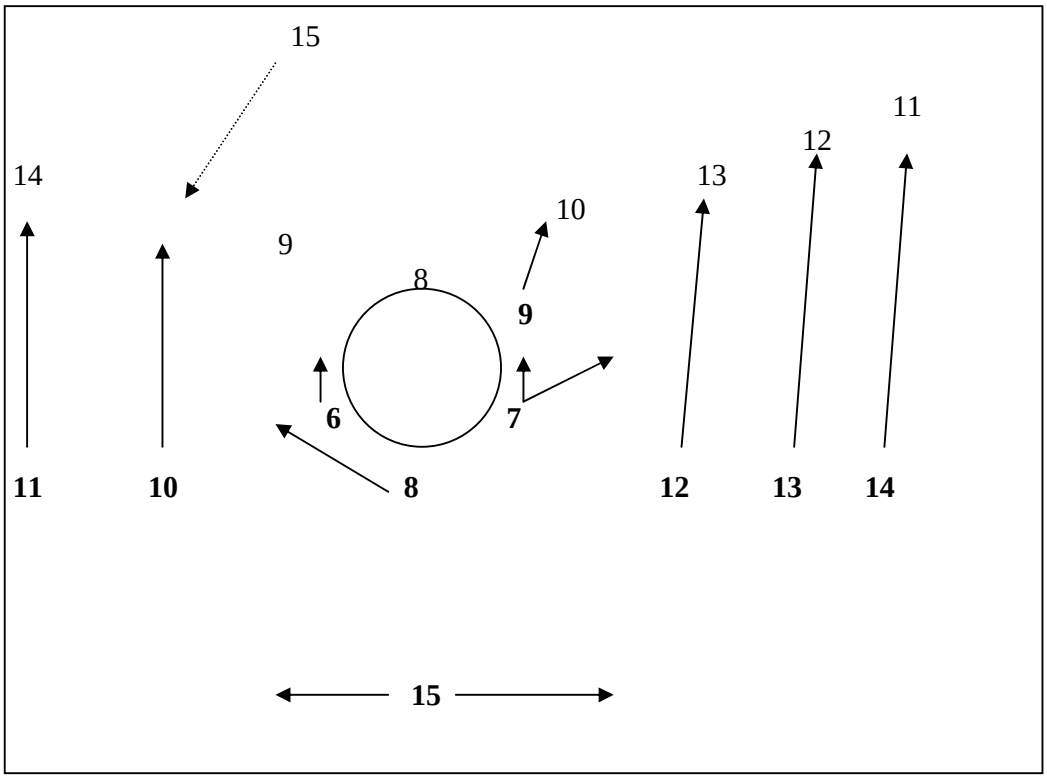
9 does the same as man on man defence from a right scrum.
10 moves across the field and takes their inside centre from the inside.
Backline also moves across the field. They take their men from the inside and stay in their channels.
6 takes their 10 and then moves across the field covering the inside gaps.
8 first covers the inside gap between their 9 and 10 and then cross covers.
7 and **14** do the same as above.
Tight Forwards do the same.

Defence from a Midfield Scrum:



9 will always takes the first man on the right.
10 will always take 10 on the left.
Backline always takes their man.
15 covers either side.
Flankers will always watch for the pick up and then cover the first channel to the scrum or fall back deep. They then move across the field covering the inside gaps.
Wings will either be taking their man or falling back a bit for the box kick before cross covering. The outside man is always his man.
Tight Forwards: the three closest to the ball take the shortest route and the other two take a deeper route.

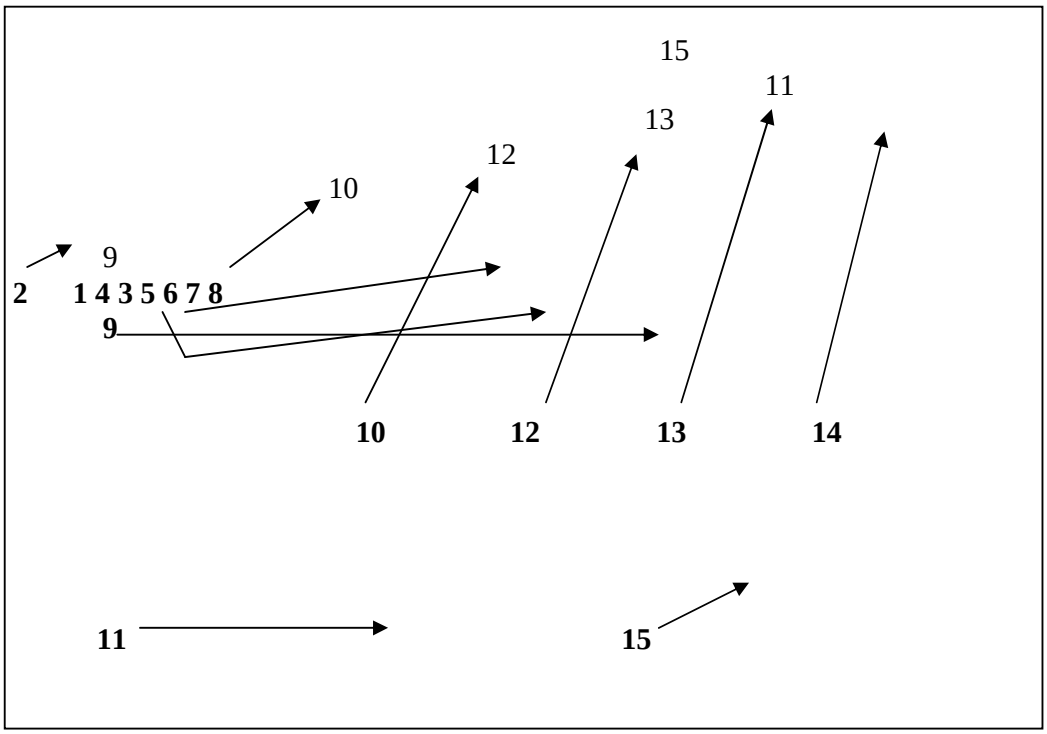
Big blind on the Left:



10 will leave 9 for **8** and take 15.
8 take 9.

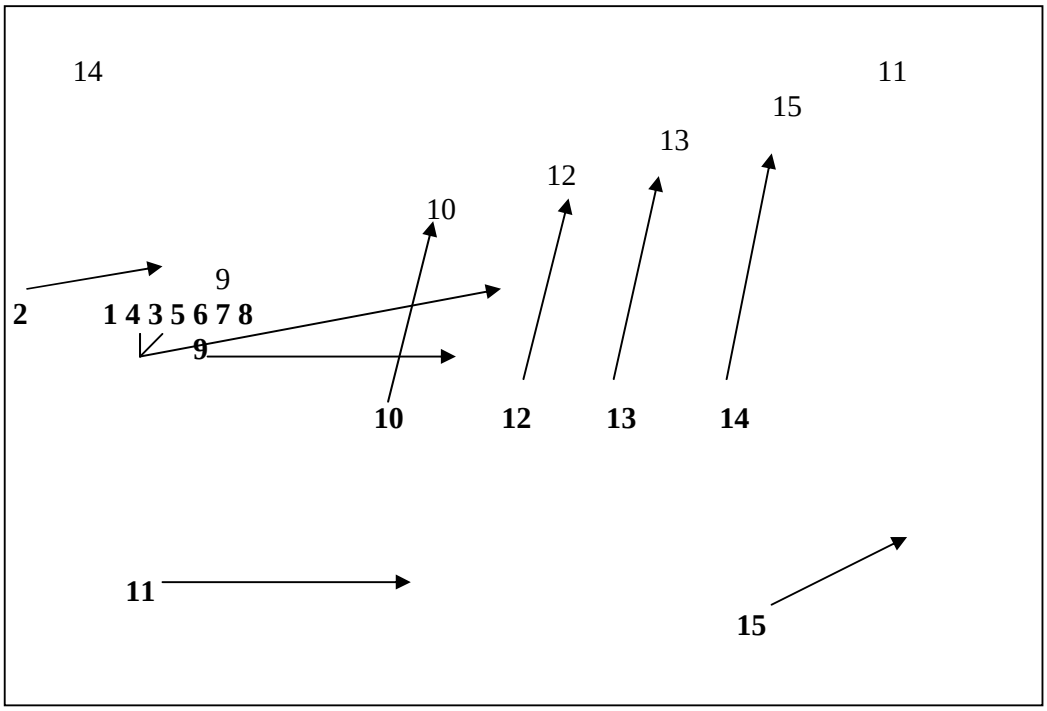
Defence from the Lineout:

A. *When the ball goes to 2 or 4*:



Loose Forwards are in the game so they can defend.
8 takes 10 and then covers the inside gaps.
7 moves across the field staying on the inside of the ball watching for any inside breaks just in front of the advantage line.
6 moves across the field along the advantage line, staying on the inside of the ball.
9 also moves across the field behind the advantage line, watching for any chips.
11 checks for the box kick and then cross covers.
2 applies pressure on 9 and then comes across. If they drive he stands off on the blind.
Tight Forwards take the shortest root to the ball while covering the blind together.

B. *When the ball goes to the back*:



Loose forwards are out of it, but must work hard to get back into the game.
Backline tackles man on man.
Tight Forwards must try and watch the inside gaps while cross covering.
11 does the same as above.
2 also does the same as above.

If there is a short lineout our forwards must defend against their forwards standing off.

Obviously the same defensive patterns off the left lineout apply to the right lineout.

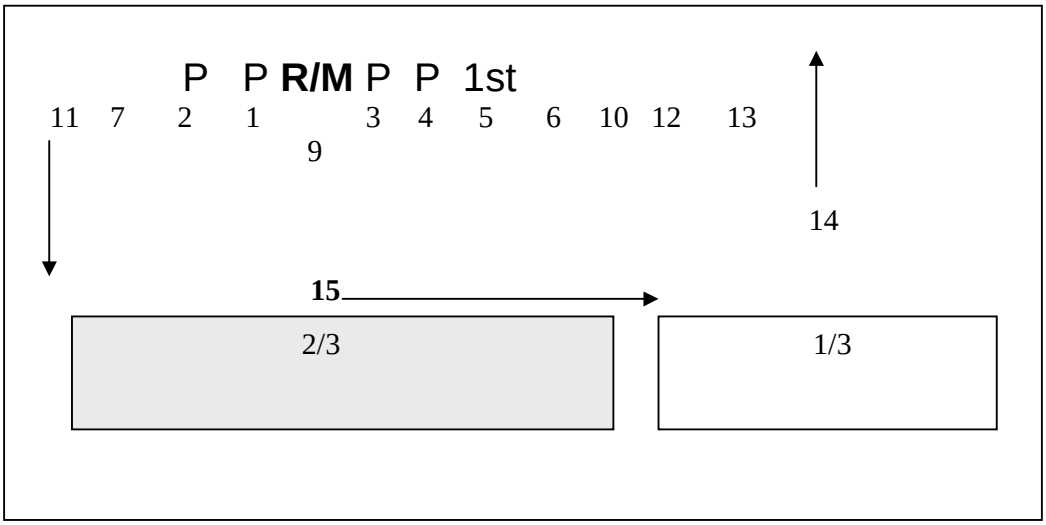
Special Lineout Defence:

Put the fastest loose forward in the backline. He gets used to rush/pressurise their 10 or centre. As soon as the ball is tapped, he goes as fast as he can. The backs defend as usual behind him.

Or play this loose forward at scrumhalf and let him stand at the back of the lineout. He will then have less distance to cover.

'Sacking' can be used to defend a drive.

Defence in Open Play:



Pillars: 1 and 3
Must watch for a pick and go and then cover inside of the Post.
Pillar must make sure that everyone is behind the last mans feet at the ruck.

Posts: 2 and 4
Watch for a break by the scrumhalf and then cover the inside of the 1st defender.
The Post man shouts "Hold, hold, …" while watching the scrumhalf and the ball.
Once the ball is in play he shouts "Press!" or "Rush!" and the rest of the defensive line comes up together, while making sure that their inside defender is slightly in front of them.

1st Defender: The 1st Defender tackles the first receiver. If the 1st receiver passes the ball he then covers the inside of the next defender.

The tight forwards must always work their way in, to defend around the ruck or maul. We can't have tight forwards defending the opposition's backs.
The "Pillar" and "Post" must take up their positions as soon as possible. They always go up and shut out the inside gaps.
Players must be behind the last mans feet at the ruck.
New defenders file in on the outside of the 1st defender.
The inside defender must always watch for the inside step by the next attacking player after his man has passed.
Remember that to be beaten on the outside the attacker has to be really quick, this is why they often step back inside.

REMEMBER TO COMMUNICATE!

Defence in General:

It is obvious that rugby players prefer attack to defense, but by putting in extra work on defense, your attack can actually improve.

The tackling technique you use on the field depends on the situation that you are in.

- Always keep your opponent on your outside. This way you will have less distance to cover and will need less speed. Tackle inside hip.
- Tackle the ball. It is an easier target than his legs and can't mislead you, but watch out for the hand off.
- Keep your eyes open at all times!
- Never give your opponent time or space. Go to him don't let him come to you.
- No studs showing and get close to the attacker, arms up, hit with the shoulder, clamp arms and lift opposite leg and twist.
- If you are tackling head on. Tackle him in an upward movement to counter his forward movement. This tackle should put him back. Or just take him low.
- If your opponent is running at you and you are stationery and have little momentum you can grab his jersey and pull him down (this is known as riding the tackle) or take him around the ankles. His momentum should bring himself down. This tackle will stop the movement but won't take him backwards (get on your feet and steal the ball or slow it down).
- When tackling side on you can go for his mid rib area, hips, thighs or ankles. Remember to get your head out of the way to avoid injury.
- You will always put your man down if you take him low.
- Commitment is the key in tackling. How committed are you?

It is important to prevent the wing from coming in and leaving a gap out wide, and also for communication to take place constantly.

If you are ever in a 1 on 2 situation, never rush up (delay your commitment to an attacker). This will give your team mates time to get back and help.

You have to constantly be on your toes to react when defending. You must also have the correct stance on defence as well as the fact that once a pass has been made, the defender who was not on cue is not off the hook. You need to work! Still come up and watch the inside.

After making a tackle get back onto your feet as quickly as possible.

The roles and responsibilities at the breakdown are important, and a team needs to be technically astute and aggressive at the tackle ball area. If we dominate the collision area, it will buy time for the defense to dominate the next collision area. The majority of the game is spent in this area and if we can dominate here we will win any game.

Where was Henry Honibal's point of contact when his shoulders crashed into his opponents? It was just above the waist. This is the softest and most vulnerable area of your opponent. Why go for a hard, moving target like his legs, if you can go for a soft stationery target.
The most important part in tackling is the contact with the shoulder, the clamping of the arms and then driving him back with leg power. (Eyes open, Shoulder and Arms)

Backline:

- In our 22m we always defend man on man
- Stay in your channels and come up together
- Vary the speed that you come up. This will confuse your opponents.
- Offensive defence (be aggressive)
- Communication
- Commitment

Forwards:

- 10m from our line we never contest their lineout and watch for the drive or peel.
- If they drive or maul remember low body positions and lift their legs or sack. Work together and try to isolate their ball carrier. Hit them hard and fast, drive them back and split them. Remember the 3 point stance.
- Tight forwards need to watch the first channel of the rucks.
- Loose forwards must stand out and mark their loose forwards. They must watch for the overlaps and work hard cross covering. Remember to watch the outside and inside channel of your flyhalf and to cover all the inside gaps.
- Offensive defence
- Communication
- Commitment